Game Design Concept - Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy

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Project overview

Working title: Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy (WYDRA)
Genre: Narrative alchemy adventure, cozy, simulation, puzzle
Perspective: Third person, 2D, pixel
Player character: Rob, an otter spirit familiar
Setting: Fantasy inspired by 17th-century Poland and Sarmatian culture
Primary progression: Knowledge, memories, relationships, alchemical understanding

High Concept

A young alchemist accidentally summons the spirit of a long-dead otter. Together they study alchemy in an isolated tower, hoping to recreate the otter's physical form. As the spirit recovers fragmented memories of his former life, however, both discover that remembering who he was may be different from deciding who he is now.

Core fantasy

Be an otter. Explore a strange alchemical world. Learn how things work. Build a relationship with a young alchemist. Recover a forgotten life. Decide what it means to come back.

Unique selling points

The player is controlling the spirit of a dead creature to be resurrected.

This deconstructs the usual resurrection tropes and allows the player to explore the philosophical dilemma of "old life" vs "new life", leaving it up to player whether they want to come back in the end.

Alchemy is learned through experimentation and understanding, not recipes.

The first thing the player learns about alchemy is that the ingredients don't matter, but their properties do. This deconstructs the usual crafting system flow: find a recipe, gather ingredients, craft an item.

Player's relationship with Yan keeps track of what was said and had happened.

The characters remember player's choices and those memories shape how they understand each other.

Design pillars

Curiosity and experimentation

The player progresses by understanding systems and experimenting with the world around them. They should be encouraged to remain curious and draw conclusions based on both successful and failed experiments. The player should feel like they are in a safe space.

Discovery should precede explanation

Rather than relying on exposition, tutorial and checklists, I want the player to discover the world through experience, inference and understanding.

Systems should express the story

Alchemy, memory, exploration, relationships, and the workshop should reinforce the same themes.

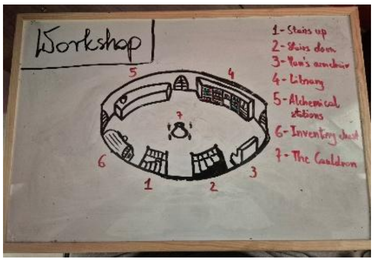
The world remembers

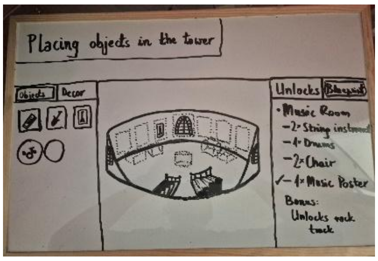
Actions should have consequences that can return later. Characters don't simply reset after conversations but can reference a hurtful or a kind line later in the story.

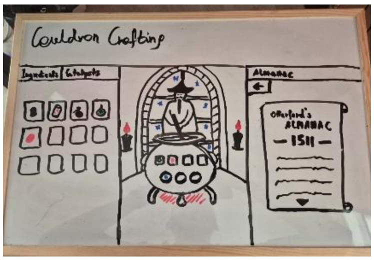
Past and present should coexist

Rob's historical life matters, but the game shouldn't imply that his old life is automatically more important than his new one.

Concept art


Workshop
1- Stairs up
2- Stairs down
3- Yan's armchair
4- Library
5- Alchemical stations
6- Inventory chest
7- The Cauldron
5
4
7
6
1
2
3


Placing objects in the tower
Objects
Decor
Unlocks
Blueprint
• Music Room
– 2x String instrum
– 1x Drums
– 2x Chair
✓ – 1x Music Poster
Bonus:
Unlocks rock track


Cauldron Crafting
Ingredients
Catalysts
Almanac
←
Otterford's ALMANAC
– 1511 –